

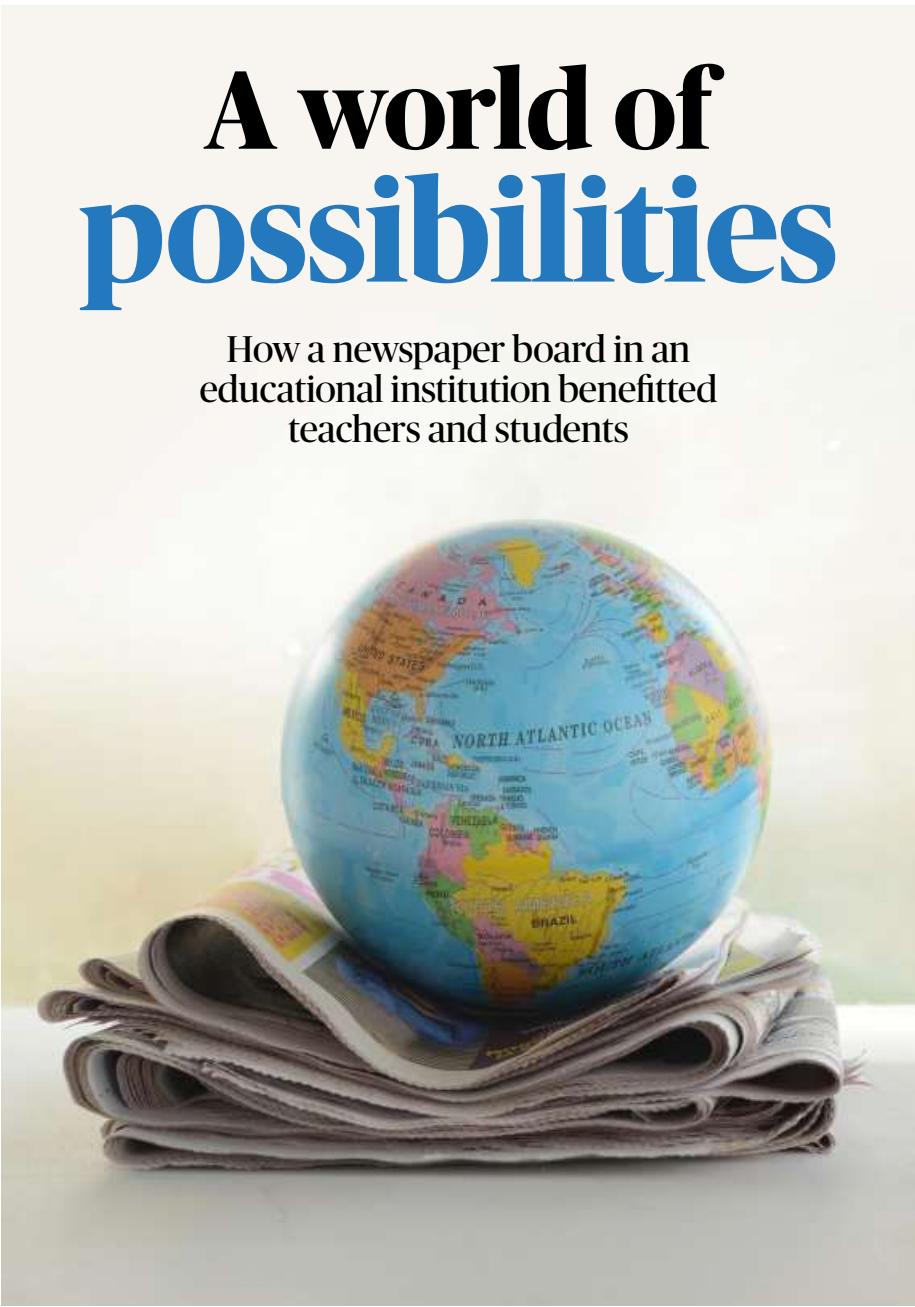
Nimesh Ved

Recently, a board was installed at our institution to put up newspaper articles. The idea was to encourage students and teachers to read newspapers. Actually, to just read. We began with an open mind and four dailies. We were keen to get to know of the developments in the country and the subjects we pursued.

Introducing themes
We began by reading and rereading the newspapers, short-listing articles, pondering over them, and neatly putting them up on the boards. In the course of a few weeks, we increased the board area and made it more reader-friendly. ‘Shall we read?’ talked of parents’ and book stores’ efforts to increase reading. We were doing our bit here. Next came the themes.

AI is extensively written about these days. We put up articles on how it reinforces gender and caste biases (Sociology) or even on how it discourages creativity. We also had articles on the water guzzling and carbon footprint (Education for Sustainable Development) that go into the development of AI. The details and the numbers left all of us surprised.

Civics followed. Newspapers had extensively covered the municipal elections in the state. This helped us discuss political parties, youth participation, voting practices, results, fair elections and de-



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mocracy as a whole. We realised that our awareness of local bodies was not something we could be proud of.

Leopards were all over

the landscape and the news, so they got dedicated space (EVS). We talked about how these sightings have a seasonal trend, possible long-term solutions at

a landscape level and so on. This was of avid interest, especially as a leopard was trapped by the forest department not far from the institution.

The next step

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help



OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

My daughter is in Class 10 (CBSE). She is not interested in Engineering or Medicine and is passionate about Photography. She would like to explore Psychology to see what it is about. Should she pursue the Humanities? Gina

Dear Gina,
Humanities is a natural fit for her interests. Let her opt for Psychology in Classes 11 and 12 to test the waters and build a solid foundation for a B.A./B.Sc. Psychology.
Photography is fundamentally about storytelling, culture, and human emotion. Subjects such as History, Sociology, Psychology, Art, English Literature, and Media Studies will deepen her understanding of people and her photography skills.
If her school allows cross-stream choices, pairing Humanities with Applied Maths will benefit future psychology research. Psychology and photography together can lead to careers in Visual Journalism, Documentary Photography, Art Therapy, Advertising and Consumer Behaviour, and Media Psychology.

I have completed Class 12 (History, Business Studies, Economics, Psychology, and English) and plan to do B.A. Political Science. I want to prepare for the UPSC exams. Given its competitive nature, what are the alternative paths or skills I should consider? Hanna

Dear Hanna,
B.A. in Political Science overlaps with the UPSC General Studies papers, especially Polity, International Relations, Governance, and Modern

History. Your instinct to build a Plan B is smart. Public Policy and Governance offers opportunities in consultancy, government, international organisations, and think tanks. CSR and NGO Management are also growing options.

Political Consulting and Election Campaign Management offer roles such as political strategist, campaign manager, and content writer. You could also consider research or psephology.

Build practical skills alongside your degree. Learn Advanced Excel and SPSS or R Programming. Policy writing, digital communication, and public relations are equally valuable.

Balance both goals without burning out. Maintain a strong GPA, read and analyse a national newspaper and intern with MLAs, MPs, think-tanks, NGOs, or CSR teams. Build a LinkedIn profile and connect with professionals in Public Policy and CSR to gain insights into careers beyond the civil services.

I completed my graduation in 2024 and am preparing for the Banking exams. During my education, I did not understand concepts but studied for exams. Now, I cannot handle the syllabus for the banking exams. How can I build my foundation? Govind

Dear Govind,
You need a reset. Banking exams such as IBPS, SBI, and RBI test conceptual clarity, speed, and logical application.

For Quantitative Aptitude, download the free NCERT Maths textbooks for Classes 6-10 and focus on mastering

the concepts of data interpretation, percentages, profit and loss, simple and compound interest, ratios, and averages.

For Logical Reasoning, begin with topics that follow fixed rules, such as Syllogisms (using Venn diagrams), Blood Relations (family trees), Direction Sense, and Inequalities. Train your brain to convert text into visual maps before attempting complex puzzles.

Banking English is not about speaking fluently or memorising vocabulary. Read an editorial in a national newspaper daily and observe sentence structure. The more correct English you read, the easier it becomes to recognise errors.

Remember, speed is the result of accuracy, which comes from clarity. For four to six weeks, solve questions without worrying about time. Your brain has to build the foundation it missed earlier. Start with a disciplined, low-stress routine. Progress may feel slow, but once your concepts are strong, both your speed and confidence will improve.

I am in Class 10 (CBSE). I have a good aptitude for Maths and Science and also enjoy English greatly. But I feel uncertain about my future due to the rapid growth of AI. I am unsure which stream would be most suitable for me. Please help me make an informed decision. Vedanshi

Dear Vedanshi,
Maths and Science develop analytical thinking and problem-solving, while English builds communication, critical thinking, and contextual

understanding. AI excels at repetitive tasks but struggles where quantitative logic meets human creativity. Your strengths lie at that intersection.

If you choose Science (PCM), you will lay a strong foundation. Strong mathematical concepts like calculus, probability, and linear algebra will remain valuable.

English complements this by helping you explain complex technical ideas clearly, an increasingly important skill in technical communication.

With the Humanities or Liberal Arts with Applied Mathematics, you can explore AI-resilient fields such as Computational Linguistics, Cognitive Science, and AI Ethics.

Commerce with Core Maths is another excellent option if you enjoy economics, finance, and business systems.

Instead of worrying about jobs seven years from now, focus on building skills that AI cannot easily copy. Learn basic Python through free platforms like Kaggle or Codecademy to see if you enjoy coding. Also explore Computational Linguistics, which combines language and mathematics to power tools like ChatGPT.

Remember, AI is a tool. Humans provide the intent, creativity, ethics, and empathy.

Your strength in English helps you communicate and think critically, while your aptitude for Maths helps you solve problems logically.

Whatever stream you choose, keeping both sides of your brain active will make you adaptable in the future.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

Importance of history

The idea behind having History on the board was to underscore that the subject was alive and being discussed as it impacted our present and future. The articles talked of new galleries coming up in museums, new evidence uncovered in excavations, conserving and displaying significant relics, and even a ‘Return to Harappa’, which talked about toy kits around history. History was not exactly popular and some students would ask why they needed to learn history. These discussions helped address that, to some extent.

The ongoing debates in the country during the period were extensively covered in the newspapers: the Vande Mataram controversy, UGC regulations, Keezhadi excavations, the changes to the NCERT textbooks, what was going on with the Aravallis, and even the Preamble to the Constitution. These presented an opportunity for the classroom to engage with topics being discussed elsewhere, to read views and opinions of others, and agree/ disagree with them. More importantly, to learn to agree and disagree.

Then there were articles on books: reviews, author interviews, reports on literature festivals and reading. Among authors who got space were Salman Rushdie, Kiran Desai, and Satoshi Yagisawa, who had new books and Hindi writer Vinod Kumar Shukla, who passed away.

To our surprise, the most popular article was the one on the Japanese automobile company Suzuki making and selling Indian curries in Japan. Initially, we were unsure whether this was for real, but the article led to discussions about innovation and collaboration.

Benefits

At one level, the entire exercise was about skimming through newspapers, reading shortlisted articles, pondering over them, putting them up neatly on the boards, and learning about the country. At another level, however, it was about realising that newspapers talk about and mirror the world, which is doing what it has always done: change and evolve. It was up to us to decide what we took from the newspaper. To me, personally, reading newspapers benefited my students and me.

We had taken the initial steps. We could connect the articles with our experiences (travel, reading, conversations), or read further on topics of interest, or learn the language (including how to write better), or take cognisance of the changes around us (new writers aka fresh voices emerging, cultural spaces coming up in cities), and be aware of the worlds beyond the small world we inhabit in a society that is increasing getting more insular.

The writer has been an educator and administrator in education institutions.



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Ctrl + Alt + Learn

Why hackathons teach more than classrooms

Amit Kumar Sinhal

In a traditional classroom, learning is spread across semesters and years, focusing on in-depth understanding and critical analysis of key concepts. Hackathons, on the other hand, compress months of theoretical understanding into a brief and intense time frame that forces participants to prioritise problem-solving, execution, and adaptability.

Sense of urgency

Students who appear comfortable in structured classroom settings are often initially challenged in hackathons but adapt quickly when placed in high-pressure, real-world situations. Instead of passively absorbing information, they are required to apply their knowledge immediately. This creates a sense of urgency that sharpens focus and accelerates learning in ways classrooms rarely achieve. More importantly, hackathons help foster a culture of innovation among the students.

One of the most significant limitations of classroom education is its reliance on memorisation and theoretical assessments. Hackathons flip this model. Participants learn by building, whether coding an application, designing a prototype, or solving a real-world problem. This approach leads to deeper understanding because concepts are experienced, not just studied. Struggling through a bug late at night or pivoting midway through a solution creates insights no textbook can replicate. From repeated mentoring experience, students who participate in hackathons demonstrate stronger conceptual clarity when revisiting similar topics in class.

Hackathons are centred on real-world challenges, from healthcare to sustainability and finance. Unlike classroom assignments that may feel abstract, hackathon problems demand practical and scalable solutions. Participants must consider usability, feasibility, and impact within a limited time. This exposure to con-

SCHOLARSHIPS



Inlaks Fine Arts Awards

Offered by the Inlaks Shivdasani Foundation

Eligibility: Indian passport holders or those currently residing in India born on or after January 1, 1996 who are emerging artists or a recent graduate or postgraduate in visual arts or a final-year student enrolled in an Indian visual arts institute.

Rewards: ₹300,000/ year
Application: Online
Deadline: August 15
www.b4s.in/edge/IFAAl

Schaeffler India Hope Engineering Scholarship

Offered by Schaeffler India.

Eligibility: Female students enrolled in the first year of an Engineering programme at a government-recognised college with at least 60% in Class 12 (Science stream) in 2025-26 (40% for PwD applicants) and an annual family income not exceeding ₹500,000.

Rewards: ₹50,000 a year for four years.

Application: Online
Deadline: August 15
www.b4s.in/edge/SIHEI7

Indus Towers Scholarship

A CSR initiative by Indus Towers Ltd. (formerly Bharti Infratel).

Eligibility: Indian nationals with a benchmark disability of 40% or more who are pursuing an eligible course, including higher secondary, graduation, PG, Master's, Diploma, certificate, vocational and skill development programmes, or coaching for employment-oriented competitive exams and have got 45% in the qualifying exam and belong to the BPL or EWS categories with an annual family income not exceeding ₹800,000.

Rewards: Up to ₹75,000.
Application: Online
Deadline: August 22
www.b4s.in/edge/ITSP5

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Conference



The British Council is organising the South Asia TeachingEnglish Online Conference 2026.

This free three-day event will bring together educators, researchers and teachers from Bangladesh, India, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri

Lanka to examine one of the most pressing questions facing education today: how can schools equip learners with the creativity, adaptability and communication skills needed to thrive in an increasingly complex world?

Dates: July 23-25

For details, visit <https://shorturl.at/sEZx8>

ments, failure is often penalised, encouraging caution.

Hackathons encourage the opposite mindset. Many teams do not complete their projects, and many ideas fail, but each failure offers valuable learning. Participants learn to iterate quickly, accept feedback, and move forward. From a mentor's perspective, some of the most meaningful growth occurs in teams that do not win but reflect and improve. This ability to treat failure as feedback is critical in innovation-driven fields but largely absent in traditional systems.

Classrooms often rely on grades as motivation, which can lead to surface-level learning. Hackathons are driven by curiosity and the desire to create. Participants choose problems they care about and work on ideas they find meaningful. This intrinsic motivation leads to deeper engagement. Many students voluntarily return to hackathons not for grades, but for the experience. This is rarely seen with traditional assignments.

Not a substitute

Hackathons are not a substitute for formal education. Classrooms provide foundational knowledge and structure that remain essential. However, combining theoretical depth with applied time-bound learning can create a more balanced educational experience. The comparison between 48 hours and four years is not just about time; it's about effectiveness. Hackathons condense learning into a dynamic, immersive experience that emphasises action, collaboration, and real-world relevance. In doing so, they reveal an important truth: sometimes, the most meaningful learning doesn't happen over years of study, but in a few intense, unforgettable days.

The writer is Professor of Computer Science and Engineering, JK Lakshmiipat University, Jaipur.

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